



“Condemnation of productive diesel locomotives prematurely means wastage of a high-cost resource... Railways should have phased them out gradually”

SANJIV GARG

FORMER ADDITIONAL MEMBER,
RAILWAY BOARD



“The introduction of advanced locomotives is crucial to realising the government’s aspiration to elevate the Railways’ share in freight movement from 27% to 45%”

SUNIL MATHUR

MANAGING DIRECTOR & CEO, SIEMENS LTD

This state-of-the-art plant commenced operations in 2018. In all, 700 locomotives have already been supplied. The remaining 300 will be supplied by FY28. These engines, with a 35-year lifespan, will become part of the Railways’ 2,500-strong emergency fleet.

There are concerns around the future of the Marhowra factory. “The contract stands (for delivery of the remaining 300 locomotives). For the future, we will focus on local domestic opportunities with railways, export, and components so that the massive infrastructure is used,” says Sujatha Narayan, Senior Vice President and India Region Leader from Watbtec.

These high-power loco-

tives—with a combination of 4,500 horsepower and 6,000 horsepower—were for freight movement. However, all trains on both east and west dedicated freight corridors are now hauled by electric locomotives.

Watbtec is also exploring export options with the first two of the 70 ordered by Rio Tinto are headed to Africa. These will support rail operations for the Simandou high-grade iron ore project, located in southeast Guinea, Africa’s largest mining and infrastructure development project. Watbtec has an export order for 140 locomotives.

FREIGHT DELAYS

The electric locomotive shortage is acting as a roadblock to railways’

plans to double the freight share in the next five years from the present 27%. Container train operators (CTOs) have been demanding permission for the private sector to procure locomotives and maintain rolling stock. At present, CTOs in India cannot own locomotives. This differs from the private freight train operators of other countries such as Germany, the US, and the UK, where freight train operators can exercise more control over their delivery schedules by owning and operating their locomotives.

“In India, the supply of locomotives is the responsibility of Indian Railways; thus, CTOs depend on these locomotives’ availability. Since the locomotives are shared between passenger and freight trains, their availability is uncertain, particularly when a locomotive breaks down en route. This translates into a loss of revenue because of the reduced number of trips and penalties for delayed delivery,” says a recent report by Ficci.

According to freight players, improvements have been noted in terms of locomotive supply at terminals.

However, en route delays continue to pose a substantial challenge, and to overcome them, it is essential to manage the availability of locomotives around high-density routes, ensuring prompt response during breakdowns.

According to the CTOs, the Dedicated Freight Corridor Corporation India Ltd is in discussion with the Railways to consider developing its locomotive capabilities instead of relying solely on assets of the Railways.

PRIVATE PARTICIPATION

The two aforementioned private players—Siemens Ltd and Alstom—are complementing the